



exams, I was out playing cricket. When I got back, my mum took my cricket bat and set it ablaze, warning me to start studying. I was furious, but she was firm and made sure I studied.” The arson did not quell Rajeev’s love for cricket; he continued to play, and to this day, he makes it a point to watch India’s World Cup cricket matches live with his friends.

A brilliant public speaker at school, Rajeev’s mornings usually began in front of the microphone on the stage of Rajagiri High School, Kochi, delivering the morning school prayers at the Catholic school, and then standing in line to be punished for mischief right after.

Oblivious to his mother’s business dealings and prompted by necessity, Rajeev started a full-fledged business venture in the ninth grade. His love for comics and the lack of high-end Tintin and Asterix comics propelled him to start a comic rental service on his school bus every morning. “My dad had given me some money to buy Amar Chitra Katha comics, but I had to find a way to get expensive Tintin, Asterix, and other Western comics. I came up with the idea to rent out my Amar Chitra Katha comics to other kids on the bus,” he recounts.

Every morning, on the 45-minute bus ride, young Rajeev, along with two of his friends, ran this little operation. “We carried only a few textbooks in our big school bags; the rest were comics we rented out on the bus,” he grins mischievously.

Like any business, this too came with its share of problems. Being one of the smallest kids in the ninth grade—only about four feet nine inches (145cm) tall—some kids would skip paying back the money. Sharp as a button, Rajeev discloses his innovative solution to this grave problem: “I made a deal with the biggest guy in class. He was actually a nice guy, but the kids feared him because of his sheer size. Our deal allowed him to read the comics first and, in return, he would collect the money from the kids who had not paid me.”

The business venture ended in the first semester of the tenth grade when the school principal caught the kids collecting money on the bus, resulting in the suspension of Rajeev and his two co-founders from the school bus.

Back then, the concept of encouraging entrepreneurial skills was non-existent. Despite the public shame in school, Rajeev’s father supported him for starting an honest business venture to buy all his favourite comics. “The cash flow from renting out those comics allowed me to buy more books, read more, and earn more,” he says proudly.

Years later, the school invited him to give a talk about entrepreneurship. “I started my speech by



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